Artificial Intelligence (AI) and the 2027 Elections: Comparing Urban and Rural Voters' Responses to AI-Generated Campaign Messages in Abia State, Nigeria

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Abstract

Artificial intelligence (AI) is entering Nigerian electoral communication ahead of the 2027 general elections, raising concerns about authenticity, trust and misinformation. This exploratory study examined how voters aged 18-40 in Abia State, Nigeria, understand, feel about and respond to AI-generated and AI-assisted campaign messages, and how urban/semi-urban and rural voters compare. Method: A qualitative exploratory design was adopted. Twenty voters (ten urban/semi-urban and ten rural) were purposively selected from communities across Abia State and interviewed individually using six AI-generated or AI-assisted campaign materials (CM1-CM6), supplemented by observation notes. Data were analysed through reflexive thematic analysis and interpreted with the Elaboration Likelihood Model. Findings: AI familiarity varied within both groups rather than simply between them. Participants separated emotional appeal from credibility, and realistic fabrication caused more concern than obvious satire. The messages stimulated attention, discussion and verification more readily than candidate support, and rural participants relied more on interpersonal and community verification networks. Conclusion: Within this sample, AI-generated campaign messages shaped electoral judgement through credibility, emotional appeal, realism and verification conditions rather than automatic vote conversion. As exploratory findings, these are not statistically generalisable but offer propositions for larger studies.

Keywords: Artificial intelligence, Elections, Voters, Campaigns, Deepfakes, Credibility, Persuasion, Verification, Abia State, Nigeria

Introduction

Nigeria's 2027 general elections are scheduled for 16 January 2027 (presidential and National Assembly) and 6 February 2027 (governorship and State Houses of Assembly). Under the revised timetable of the Independent National Electoral Commission (INEC), campaigns for the federal elections began on 19 August 2026 and those for the state elections on 9 September 2026, and all campaigns must end 24 hours before polling day (Oliji, 2026). The 2027 campaign is therefore the first Nigerian general election campaign to unfold while generative AI tools are cheap and widely available.

AI is increasingly being integrated into electoral communication, giving political agents tools to quickly and cost-effectively tailor text, images, audio and video content while posing fresh challenges of authenticity, accountability and trust (Juneja, 2024; Chowdhury, 2024). In Nigeria, the 2023 elections marked a visible entry point: a viral audio clip purporting to capture Atiku Abubakar, Ifeanyi Okowa and Aminu Tambuwal plotting to rig the election was found to be a doctored deepfake (Shibayan, 2023). In West Africa, OpenAI (2025) reported an AI-generated influence operation that produced partisan articles and comments ahead of Ghana's 2024 election. Technical capacity, however, does not guarantee a uniform impact. In experiments around elections in the United States, Canada and Poland, Lin et al. (2025) found that dialogues with AI significantly shifted candidate preferences, while Neyazi et al. (2025), who studied 1,627 people in India, did not find a boost in affective polarization after reading about campaign deepfakes. These results challenge deterministic claims about the persuasive effects of AI-generated political messages. The distinction is

particularly relevant in Africa, where political information does not travel only through the Internet: Gadjanova et al. (2022) show how misinformation spans digital divides through interpersonal and socially mediated communication in northern Ghana, and Hassan (2023) found that electoral misinformation in Nigeria moves through social and traditional media.

This study is set in Abia State, south-east Nigeria, which has 17 local government areas, 4,069 polling units and over two million registered voters (Okoronkwo, 2023). The state combines urban commercial and administrative centres, notably Aba and Umuahia, with semi-urban towns and rural farming communities. The study focuses on voters aged 18-40, a group heavily exposed to political content online (Mustapha & Omar, 2020). This group is not homogeneous. In Nigeria, where mobile internet spread mainly after 2010, younger voters grew up with smartphones and social media and can be regarded as digital natives, whereas older voters in the bracket adopted digital technologies later and resembled digital immigrants (Prensky, 2001). Such differences, together with uneven internet access between urban and rural areas (Conroy-Krutz et al., 2024; Kemp, 2024), may shape how AI-generated messages are understood.

Existing scholarship does not adequately capture how such messages are understood and acted upon in Nigerian communities. First, influential experimental studies are geographically limited to North America, Europe and India, and their results cannot be assumed to apply to Abia State (Lin et al., 2025; Neyazi et al., 2025). Second, Nigerian studies have found that misinformation can affect voter attitudes, trust in the electoral process and democracy, but they focus on misinformation generally rather than on generative-AI campaign content or on comparing flyers, synthetic audio and short videos (Hassan, 2023; Akinola et al., 2024). Third, African studies show differences in access to, and verification of, information, but there is little evidence on whether these differences lead to different reactions to AI-generated electoral messages among urban, semi-urban and rural voters (Gadjanova et al., 2022; Azeez et al., 2026).

Because the phenomenon is new and these questions have not been examined in Abia State, an exploratory approach is appropriate: rather than measuring effects across the electorate, it seeks in-depth understanding and propositions for later testing (Stebbins, 2001). The study contributes to scholarship by providing early evidence from a Nigerian state on AI-generated campaign messages ahead of the 2027 elections, by comparing urban/semi-urban and rural voters, a contrast largely absent from AI-persuasion research, and by extending the Elaboration Likelihood Model to AI-generated political content in a hybrid online-offline information environment. Practically, it offers INEC, parties, journalists and civil society insight for voter education during the campaign.

This exploratory study therefore explores how voters aged 18-40 in urban, semi-urban and rural Abia State comprehend, feel about and react to AI-generated political campaign messages delivered as flyers, audio recordings and short videos. Specifically, it sought to:

examine how voters aged 18 to 40 in Abia State understand AI-generated campaign messages;

explore how voters feel about AI-generated campaign flyers, audio messages, and short videos;

examine how AI-generated campaign messages influence voters' willingness to seek more information, discuss a candidate, or support a candidate;

compare the responses of urban and semi-urban voters with those of rural voters to AI-generated campaign messages.

Conceptual Clarification

In this study, AI-generated campaign messages are political flyers, audio clips or videos whose content is produced wholly or substantially by generative AI, such as synthetic images, cloned voices or fabricated

scenes. AI-assisted campaign messages are human-designed materials in which AI performs supporting tasks such as editing, image enhancement or drafting text (Nobel et al., 2026). Urban areas are the state's main administrative and commercial centres (Umuahia and Aba); semi-urban areas are smaller towns with mixed urban and rural features (such as Ubakala, Olokoro and parts of Isiala Ngwa); and rural areas are farming and trading communities with more limited infrastructure and internet access (such as communities in Bende, Ikwuano, Isuikwuato, Ohafia and Umunneochi).

Voters' Understanding of AI-Generated Campaign Messages

Studies by Lee and Yuan (2025), Nobel et al. (2026) and Chae and Tewksbury (2026) suggest that voters' understanding of AI-generated campaign communication relies on more than identifying the term "AI"; it involves assessing authenticity, credibility and communicative intent. This is important because politically generated AI content ranges from innocuous design help to fabricated speech. In five preregistered experiments with 2,215 participants, Groh et al. (2024) showed that individuals distinguished political deepfakes from real speeches better than chance, but not perfectly, and that audio-visual information aided recognition more than transcripts. Younger voters cannot be assumed to recognise synthetic content easily either: Dozier (2026) reported that 80% of 18-34-year-olds could only correctly identify AI images 50% of the time, and White (2025) reported that more than half of 13-18-year-olds could not determine whether AI content was true. Disclosure further complicates understanding. Harff (2026) found that labels on AI-generated images improved recognition but also lowered source credibility, and Nobel et al. (2026) found that when source credibility was low, fully AI-generated political advertisements were rated less favourably than AI-assisted ones. These studies, however, were conducted mainly outside Africa, leaving open how Nigerian voters with uneven AI exposure understand such messages.

Feelings Towards AI-Generated Flyers, Audio and Videos

Attitudes to flyers, audio and short videos are likely to be modality-specific and should not be analysed as a single attitude to AI. Flyers allow more time to consider wording and visual anomalies (Farooq & de Vreese, 2026), while audio can capitalize on familiar voices and passive listening (Groh et al., 2024). Short videos include facial expressions, body movement, emotional cues and voice, which could enhance both perceived authenticity and deceptive potential (Groh et al., 2024; Hameleers et al., 2024; Guo et al., 2026). Groh et al. (2024) also found that state-of-the-art synthetic speech was harder to identify than actor-voiced fakes, so audio-visual cues do not guarantee detection. Similarly, evidence of the persuasive power of some AI messages should not be extended to all formats. Among 4,829 respondents, Bai et al. (2025) found that LLM-generated messages changed attitudes as effectively as human-authored ones, but Hewitt et al.'s (2024) archive of 146 campaign experiments shows that the effects of political ads are small and variable. How Nigerian voters feel about each format remains largely unexamined.

Behavioural Responses: Information Seeking, Discussion and Support

Behavioural responses may also vary. AI-generated messages can prompt information seeking when they seem novel, uncertain or manipulative, whereas distrust can lead to avoidance. Mustapha and Omar (2020) found that Nigerian youths were more politically active offline than online, a caution against equating online exposure with participation. Discussion, information seeking and candidate support should therefore be distinguished; a campaign message may stimulate discussion precisely because recipients doubt it. At a larger scale, a US$8.9-million digital campaign experiment reaching two million Americans had no effect on turnout (Aggarwal et al., 2023), showing that exposure reveals little about how content is processed. Evidence on these behavioural responses among Nigerian voters exposed to AI content is lacking.

Urban-Rural Differences in Responses

The urban-rural comparison is particularly significant in Africa. Conroy-Krutz et al. (2024) found that 65% of people in 39 African countries regularly get news from radio while 47% do so via social media or the Internet, with digital use concentrated among urban, younger, better-educated and wealthier citizens. Nigeria is digitalising fast but access remains uneven: Kemp (2024) estimated that 103 million Nigerians used the Internet in early 2024 and that 54.6% of the population was urban. These figures caution against assuming social homogeneity in internet contact.

In Nigeria, WhatsApp is used for text, photos, voice notes and videos in both urban and rural areas, but Ogbodo et al. (2023) warn that digital literacy alone does not prevent sharing misinformation. Among 1,200 Nigerian youths, Azeez et al. (2026) found that urban youths were more likely to be exposed to misinformation, while rural youths were more likely to change their electoral preferences, especially when the message came from a trusted community or religious intermediary. Rural voters should therefore not be viewed as simply "less digital"; they may interpret AI through more socially mediated channels, while urban and semi-urban voters might have more exposure to AI and more scepticism or verification. No study has yet compared how these groups respond to AI-generated campaign messages.

In sum, the literature leaves four gaps that correspond to this study's objectives: limited evidence on how Nigerian voters understand AI-generated campaign messages; little attention to how they feel about different formats; scarce evidence on behavioural responses beyond persuasion; and no direct comparison of urban/semi-urban and rural voters. The question for Abia State's young voters is, therefore, not whether AI-generated messages 'work', but how format, disclosure, trust, digital access and community validation affect their processing and behavioural responses.

Theoretical Framework

The Elaboration Likelihood Model (ELM) holds that persuasion follows two routes (Petty & Cacioppo, 1986). Through the central route, people who are motivated and able to process a message scrutinise its arguments, producing stronger and more lasting attitudes. Through the peripheral route, people with low motivation or ability rely on cues such as source credibility, emotion, familiarity and presentation, producing weaker and less stable attitudes. Whether elaboration is high or low depends on motivation, such as personal relevance, and ability, such as knowledge, time and freedom from distraction (Petty et al., 1981).

Each ELM component is linked to a study variable. First, ability to elaborate corresponds to voters' AI familiarity, digital literacy and confidence in detecting synthetic content (Objective 1). Second, peripheral cues correspond to the emotional appeal, realism, recognisable political figures, religious symbols and format of the flyers, audio and videos (Objective 2). Third, central-route processing corresponds to voters' scrutiny of claims, such as checking whether a depicted alliance is real or weighing a candidate's record, while elaboration outcomes correspond to information seeking, discussion and candidate support (Objective 3). Finally, motivation and ability are shaped by context: access to data, verification opportunities and trusted community intermediaries differ between urban/semi-urban and rural settings (Objective 4). Consistent with the exploratory design, the ELM is used as an interpretive lens rather than a set of hypotheses to be tested.

Method

The study adopted a qualitative exploratory design. Exploratory research suits new phenomena where the aim is to understand how people make sense of an issue and to generate propositions, rather than to measure prevalence or test hypotheses (Stebbins, 2001). The study therefore does not claim to represent Abia State's more than two million registered voters, which would require a large probability-based survey; its urban-rural comparison is analytical rather than statistical. The design enabled participants to explain why certain messages seemed authentic, dubious or persuasive (Braun & Clarke, 2022).

Individual semi-structured interviews were preferred to focus group discussions for three reasons. Political preferences are sensitive, and group settings can produce conformity to dominant partisan views; the study needed to observe each participant's immediate, unprompted reaction to the materials; and individual interviews allowed participants with low AI familiarity to speak without being overshadowed by more digitally confident peers. Focus groups are recommended for future studies of how voters negotiate AI content collectively.

Study Area, Participants and Sampling

Twenty voters, ten urban/semi-urban and ten rural, were purposively selected from communities across Abia State. Urban participants were drawn from Umuahia and Aba, semi-urban participants from towns such as Ubakala, Olokoro and Isiala Ngwa, and rural participants from communities in Bende, Ikwuano, Isuikwuato, Ohafia and Umunneochi local government areas. Participants were aged 18-40, eligible to vote and resident in the study area. Gender, occupation, educational level, smartphone ownership, social-media usage and previous awareness of AI were considered as they may influence interpretation. Purposive sampling was appropriate for selecting information-rich cases (Ahmad & Wilkins, 2025). Sample size was guided by information power rather than statistical representativeness: a focused aim, specific participants, rich dialogue and an established analytic strategy reduce the number needed (Malterud et al., 2016). Twenty participants, ten per setting, therefore suited an exploratory comparison, although the findings are not generalisable to all voters in the state.

Table 1: Characteristics of Participants

Characteristic

Category

Frequency (n)

Percentage (%)

Total participants

20

100.0

Location group

Urban/semi-urban (e.g., Umuahia, Aba, Ubakala, Olokoro, Isiala Ngwa)

10

50.0

Rural (e.g., Bende, Ikwuano, Isuikwuato, Ohafia, Umunneochi)

10

50.0

Age eligibility

18-40 years

20

100.0

Electoral status

Eligible voters

20

100.0

Residence

Abia State

20

100.0

Campaign exposure

CM1-CM6

20

100.0

Data Collection

Semi-structured individual interviews were used to gather data. Participants were shown six campaign materials (CM1-CM6), which included AI-generated or AI-assisted flyers, audio recordings and short videos (Table 2). The researcher noted immediate reactions such as laughter, hesitation, surprise and uncertainty. Follow-up questions explored what participants observed, understood, trusted and felt, and whether the messages could prompt them to seek information, discuss or support the candidates. Using identical stimuli for all participants aided comparison.

Table 2: Campaign Materials Used as Stimuli

Code

Format

Content

Main issue raised

CM1

Short video

Satirical race between politicians, labelled as AI-made

Disclosed satire; entertainment

CM2

Short video

Politicians depicted at a Catholic Mass, labelled as AI-made

Religious cue lending moral credibility

CM3

Short Video

A political campaign material

Activity and realistic human movement

CM4

Short video

Tattered Nigerian flag with distressed faces and disaster imagery; no candidate named

Emotional appeal to economic hardship

CM5

Flyer

Purported Obi-Kwankwaso joint ticket with hook/noose imagery

Fabricated political fact; fear appeal

CM6

Video

A compilation of different campaign events

Realistic movement

Data Analysis

Braun and Clarke's reflexive thematic analysis was used to analyse the data. Transcripts and observation notes were read many times for familiarisation; statements were coded and related codes were formed into themes. Themes were reviewed against the data set, refined and named, and representative quotations were selected. Coding was mostly inductive. The Elaboration Likelihood Model was then used as an interpretive lens to examine how careful evaluation compared with rapid credibility, familiarity and emotional cues, without forcing the data into predetermined categories (Braun & Clarke, 2022; Byrne, 2022).

Ethical Considerations

Participation was voluntary, and participants gave informed consent after the purpose of the study was explained. They were assured of confidentiality and are identified only by codes (U01-U10 for urban/semi-urban and P2-P11 for rural participants).

Results

Two themes, one for each setting, were developed, each organised around the study objectives. Consistent with the exploratory design, they describe patterns within this sample and do not estimate how widely these views are held among Abia State voters.

Theme 1: Urban and Semi-Urban Voters' Perceptions and Responses to AI-Generated Political Campaign Messages

The study found that none of the ten urban and semi-urban participants accepted or rejected AI-generated political communication outright. Instead, answers depended on their knowledge of AI, the message's structure, emotional intensity, perceived authenticity, and whether synthetic manipulation was disclosed.

Understanding AI through recognition, uncertainty and disclosure

Participants' understanding of AI-generated political content varied widely. The more tech-savvy urban participants exhibited more developed notions of AI. U01 (female, 19, urban Umuahia, student, high AI familiarity), for example, understood that AI could alter multiple layers of communication: "AI-made means software generated or changed some part of the content. It may be the picture, the voice, the face, the wording, or all of it." Yet she conceded that "AI is getting better, so... you can still be fooled." U02 (male, 22, urban Aba, student, high AI familiarity) similarly identified "funny fingers", stiff faces, lip-sync problems and unnatural voices, but admitted that professionally produced AI required verification rather than visual guesswork.

This contrasted with U07 (female, 33, semi-urban Ubakala, teacher, low AI familiarity), whose prior knowledge centred mainly on ChatGPT: "I thought it was mainly for writing and answering questions." She added: "It may be difficult for me... if it is neat I may accept it." U10 (male, 40, semi-urban Isiala Ngwa, artisan/trader, low AI familiarity) similarly asked, "If it is very fake I may see it, but if it is clean, how will I know?" AI literacy thus depended less on urban residence than on prior exposure and occupational experience, as evidenced by U04's professional experience with generative design technologies.

Emotional appeal versus credibility and authenticity

Participants clearly differentiated between attention-grabbing and credible information. The politically neutral satire race, CM1, amused most urban participants (U01-U05, U07 and U08) but persuaded few. U04 (male, 27, urban Aba, graphic designer, high AI familiarity) described it as "political meme content", noting that disclosure reduced deception: "Because it says AI, I can enjoy it as satire; if the same clip removed the label and pretended to be real, I would see that as deceptive."

CM4 struck a different emotional register. The shattered Nigerian flag, distressed faces and disaster imagery brought sadness, tension and unease to U02, U03, U04, U05, U07, U08 and U09. For U04, "The visual metaphor is much heavier than ordinary campaign flyers. There is no candidate, no policy, just national pain concentrated into one image." U07's reaction was more visceral: "The faces in the flag... [pauses] that one is not easy to forget." Recognising synthetic production did not neutralise emotional impact.

CM5 raised the greatest credibility concerns. Its portrayal of an unconfirmed Obi-Kwankwaso partnership, using real political figures and official-looking design, worried U01, U03, U04, U05, U06, U08 and U09. U03 (female, 24, urban Umuahia, online retailer, moderate AI familiarity) explained: "I felt confused first, then suspicious. I would ask, is this ticket real? Because a fine graphic can make something look official when it is not." U09 (female, 38, semi-urban Olokoro, public servant, moderate AI familiarity) regarded CM5 as more dangerous than emotional imagery because it could manufacture political certainty around something that might not exist.

Attention and verification rather than automatic political support

The messages appeared more capable of stimulating attention, conversation and verification than determining vote choice. U01 explained: "It can affect my attention, not my final vote. A strong video may make me search the candidate, but I still need policies, track record and debates before support." U03, U05, U06, U07, U08 and U09 likewise prioritised competence, integrity, governance records, economic conditions and policy over campaign aesthetics.

Nevertheless, dismissing persuasive influence altogether would be misleading. U04 observed that "Repetition, colour, music and emotional framing can make a candidate feel credible before you analyse anything," and U09 argued that "Repeated exposure can influence salience and emotional orientation, even when a voter thinks he or she is being rational." For these participants, the key question was how AI was used: disclosed creative assistance was generally accepted, while synthetic impersonation, fabricated events and AI-made

claims presented as political fact raised concerns about trust.

Theme 2: Rural Voters' Perceptions and Responses to AI-Generated Political Campaign Messages

The discussion draws on ten rural participants (P2-P11).

Limited AI familiarity complicated by convincing realism

Rural participants' knowledge of AI, and their confidence in spotting it, was inconsistent. P2, P3, P7, P8, P10 and P11 had no prior substantive knowledge of AI-generated political content, while P4, P5, P6 and P9 had seen or used AI through social media, ChatGPT, synthetic images or cloned voices. For P2 (female, 21, Bende, trader, no prior AI awareness), AI had seemed remote from everyday politics: "I did not know ordinary political pictures and voices on phone could be made that way." P7 (male, 27, Umunneochi, farmer, no prior AI awareness) admitted that he might already have encountered synthetic material without recognising it.

This uncertainty persisted even among participants with prior awareness. P4 (female, 20, Isuikwuato, student, prior AI awareness) could inspect "mouth and voice, hands, eyes, shadows, writing on posters", yet conceded: "I won't boast that I can always know - these things are improving." P5, P6 and P9 expressed the same caution. Awareness of AI, therefore, did not guarantee detection. P2 captured the vulnerability: "But if it is well made, I can believe it."

Emotion, familiarity and community context shaped credibility

Some rural participants interpreted messages through familiar cultural and religious cues. CM2, which placed a politician at a Catholic Mass, was more troubling to them than obviously artificial content. P2, P3, P4, P5, P6 and others challenged the use of religion to transfer moral currency to a politician. P5 (male, 24, Ikwuano, artisan, prior AI awareness) argued that "Church attendance and good government are not the same thing." Such a familiar religious scene could circulate through WhatsApp, church networks and interpersonal discussion without immediately appearing suspicious.

CM4's damaged Nigerian flag and suffering faces generated strong emotional responses across P2-P11. P10 (female, 30, Ikwuano, trader, no prior AI awareness) stated: "It made me sad and a bit angry. You start remembering food prices, roads, unemployment... even though the video did not name them." AI imagery thus activated genuine economic grievances without evidence linking them to a candidate. Yet participants generally resisted equating emotional truth with evidential truth: hardship might be real, but the generated image did not establish responsibility.

CM5 produced suspicion rather than sadness. P2, P3, P8 and P11 were struck by the apparently official Obi-Kwankwaso pairing and the threatening hook/noose imagery. P2 explained: "My first question was, 'Did these two really announce this ticket?' The hook and noose also make me uneasy because they are telling me to fear the pairing before I even know whether the pairing is real."

Here, the danger lay in manufacturing apparent political facts from recognisable people rather than in obviously fantastic imagery.

Messages stimulated discussion and verification more readily than vote conversion

Across P2-P11, the messages were more likely to provoke curiosity, interpersonal discussion and verification than immediate support. The more digitally engaged P5 and P9 checked official pages or news sources, while P2, P3, P7, P8, P10 and P11 combined WhatsApp or Facebook searches with asking relatives, traders, farmers, community members or other trusted people. This reflects a hybrid rural information environment rather than mere digital exclusion. P8 explained that information could arrive through "WhatsApp forwarding, radio, church, market, family or one person's phone", so a convincing clip could circulate widely before its

source was examined.

Nevertheless, participants repeatedly separated attention from vote choice. P8 (female, 26, Ohafia, trader, no prior AI awareness) acknowledged that grassroots footage could make a candidate appear serious, but maintained that "voting would still depend on record, policies and whether I trust the people behind him." P10 expressed the same position, while P5 stressed that even real footage could exaggerate support.

Rural participants, therefore, did not automatically believe AI-generated campaign messages. Rather, their vulnerability centred on verification conditions: limited data, uneven AI literacy, familiar religious and community cues, trusted interpersonal circulation and highly convincing synthetic material. Accordingly, P11 called for labelling, simple verification procedures and quick corrections from "Radio stations, community leaders and journalists". For these participants, hidden manipulation, such as fake alliances, voices, crowds or religious scenes, was the most alarming threat to political trust.

Discussion of Findings

Regarding the first objective, comprehension of AI-generated campaign messages was shaped less by location than by prior exposure, digital experience and confidence in verification. Some urban participants (U01, U02, U04) were well versed in synthetic images, voices and video manipulation, whereas some semi-urban participants (U07, U10) were not, and even rural participants with AI awareness (P4, P5, P9) doubted their ability to spot it. The most AI-literate urban participants were among the youngest (U01, 19; U02, 22) and the least familiar semi-urban participants were older (U07, 33; U10, 40), consistent with the distinction between digital natives and digital immigrants (Prensky, 2001); however, young rural participants such as P2 (21) also lacked AI awareness, suggesting that access matters as much as age. These patterns align with Groh et al. (2024), Dozier (2026) and White (2025), who show that even young users struggle to identify AI content. In ELM terms, low ability to judge authenticity may push voters towards peripheral cues such as visual realism, source familiarity and presentation quality (Petty & Cacioppo, 1986).

On the second objective, participants separated emotional response from perceived credibility. Emotionally intense content such as CM4 evoked sadness, anxiety or anger but did not necessarily produce belief, consistent with Hameleers et al. (2024), Groh et al. (2024) and Guo et al. (2026), who note that audio-visual cues can evoke emotion and create opportunities for manipulation. More concerning to participants was CM5, whose recognisable politicians and 'official look' lent it apparent political reality. Realistic fabrication may therefore be more democratically consequential than disclosed satire such as CM1, extending Harff (2026) and Nobel et al. (2026) on disclosure and credibility. In ELM terms, recognisable politicians, official design conventions and evocative symbols acted as peripheral credibility cues before substantive claims were scrutinised.

On the third objective, AI-generated messages prompted attention, verification and discussion more than candidate support. Participants in both settings distinguished curiosity from voting intention and emphasised policy, competence, integrity and record. This is consistent with Hewitt et al. (2024), who show that political advertising effects are small and variable, and Aggarwal et al. (2023), who found no turnout effect from extensive digital exposure, but contrasts with Lin et al. (2025) and Bai et al. (2025), who found measurable attitude change. The difference may be methodological: experiments isolate persuasive impact, whereas interviews capture reflective judgement, and self-reports may underestimate unconscious influence, as U04 and U09 suggested. Within this sample, influence appeared indirect, operating through attention, salience and later information seeking, which in ELM terms reflects motivation to elaborate rather than immediate attitude change.

On the fourth objective, rural participants were not less sceptical, but their verification relied more on

interpersonal and community networks: relatives, churches, markets, radio and WhatsApp. This supports Gadjanova et al. (2022) and Hassan (2023) on misinformation spreading through hybrid online-offline systems, and partly supports Azeez et al. (2026) on rural vulnerability to messages from trusted intermediaries. However, rural participants often challenged political claims rather than accepting them, so the better explanation is unequal verification conditions, not rural gullibility. In ELM terms, limited data, lower AI familiarity and socially trusted cues may make the peripheral route more influential without removing critical judgement. Because the sample is small and self-reported scepticism may not predict election-day behaviour, these are propositions for larger studies rather than population-level differences.

Conclusion, Limitations and Recommendations

This exploratory study suggests that the electoral risk of AI-generated communication in Nigeria lies less in automatic vote conversion than in attention, emotion, credibility and verification. This is especially relevant as campaigns for the 2027 general elections run until January and February 2027. Interventions should therefore go beyond generic digital-literacy campaigns to verification strategies that reflect how information circulates through WhatsApp, radio, churches, markets and interpersonal networks, involving INEC, journalists, civil society groups and community leaders. Political parties should also disclose AI use in campaign materials.

The study has limitations. The sample is small, purposive and limited in scope, so the findings cannot be generalised to Abia State's electorate, and self-reported scepticism may not reflect campaign behaviour. The study focused on selected materials (CM1-CM6) rather than long-term or repeated exposure, and did not fully explore partisanship, ethnicity, religion, gender, education, algorithmic amplification or the difference between AI-assisted content and deepfakes. Future research should test these exploratory propositions through larger surveys, experiments, focus group discussions and longitudinal designs covering all 17 local government areas.

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